The Authority of Scripture



BIBLICAL TRUTHS & SOUND DOCTRINE | LESSON 1

Lesson question: Why Is the Bible Our Final Authority?

Primary passage: 2 Timothy 3:14-17

Supporting passages: 2 Peter 1:20-21; Psalm 19:7-11; John 17:17; Matthew 4:1-11; Acts 17:10-12; James 1:22-25

Central truth: The Bible is God's inspired Word, given to reveal His truth, guide our beliefs, correct our conduct, and equip us to live lives that glorify Him.

Lesson objective: Explain the divine origin of Scripture, identify its purposes, and describe how it should govern Christian belief and daily living.

Part 1 | Introduction - Who Has the Final Word?

Every day we encounter competing claims about what is true and how we should live. Religious traditions, personal experiences, cultural opinions, and respected teachers may all influence us. Yet the Christian must ask: Who or what has the final authority to determine what I believe and how I live?

Jesus prayed, "Sanctify them in the truth; your word is truth" (John 17:17, ESV). God's Word must be our standard for examining our beliefs, teachings, and conduct.

Opening discussion

Describe one situation in which a widely accepted opinion might conflict with biblical teaching. How could a believer evaluate it?

Part 2 | Observation - What Does the Passage Say?

Read 2 Timothy 3:14-17 aloud. Paul urges Timothy to continue in what he learned and reminds him of the value and source of the sacred writings.

- Verse 14: Timothy is instructed to continue in the truths he has learned.
- Verse 15: The sacred writings make a person wise for salvation through faith in Christ Jesus.
- Verse 16: All Scripture is God-breathed and profitable for teaching, reproof, correction, and training in righteousness.
- Verse 17: The result is that the servant of God is equipped for every good work.

Observation to remember: Paul identifies Scripture's divine source, its saving purpose, and its practical value for Christian service.

Part 3 | Interpretation - What Does It Mean?

1. Scripture originates from God | 2 Timothy 3:16; 2 Peter 1:20-21 The Greek term theopneustos means "God-breathed." God used human authors, with distinct vocabulary and writing styles, as the Holy Spirit worked through them to communicate His intended message. Inspiration does not mean every writer expressed himself in exactly the same way.

2. Scripture carries divine authority | John 17:17; Matthew 4:1-11 Because Scripture ultimately comes from God, it is the final authority for Christian doctrine and conduct. Jesus responded to temptation by appealing to what was written in Scripture. Divine revelation stands above human opinion.

3. Scripture is sufficient for its God-given purpose | 2 Timothy 3:15-17; Psalm 19:7-11 The Scriptures teach the way of salvation through faith in Christ and equip believers for faithful service. Sufficiency does not mean the Bible is a manual for every scientific or technical question. It means God has provided the saving truth and spiritual instruction He intends His people to have.

4. Scripture must be interpreted carefully | 2 Timothy 2:15; Acts 17:10-12 The authority belongs to Scripture, not to a teacher's personal interpretation. Read a passage in context. Ask what the biblical author meant, consider its genre and audience, and compare it with other relevant passages. The Bereans examined the Scriptures to evaluate the teaching they heard. HBM teachings should be examined in the same way.

Part 4 | Application - How Should We Respond?

Biblical Truth	Response in Daily Life
God is the source of Scripture.	Read with reverence and humility.
Scripture teaches truth.	Test personal beliefs and teachings against it.
Scripture corrects errors.	Accept correction and change course.
Scripture trains in righteousness.	Practice obedience and godly habits.
Scripture equips God’s people.	Serve faithfully and help others learn.

James 1:22-25: Hearing biblical instruction is not the same as obeying it. Spiritual growth requires us to put the Word into practice.

Part 5 | Guided Bible Study Questions

1. What does "God-breathed" tell us about the origin of Scripture?

2. According to 2 Timothy 3:15, how do the sacred writings relate to salvation?

3. Which of the four purposes in verse 16 do you most need right now: teaching, reproof, correction, or training? Why?

4. What is the difference between the authority of Scripture and the authority of someone's interpretation of Scripture?

5. How does Acts 17:11 provide an example of responsible listening and study?

6. What one action will you take this week to become a doer of God's Word?

Part 6 | A Simple Method for Examining Biblical Teaching

- Read: Read the whole passage and surrounding context.
- Observe: Identify repeated words, commands, comparisons, and the original audience.
- Interpret: Ask what the author intended to communicate.
- Confirm: Examine other relevant Scriptures without lifting them out of context.
- Apply: Identify an action that follows from the passage's meaning.

Memory Verse and Weekly Assignment

Memory verse: 2 Timothy 3:16-17. Read it in your preferred Bible translation, then explain its meaning in your own words.

Assignment: Read Psalm 19:7-11 and write down each description of God's Word and the benefit associated with it. During the week, examine one belief or habit in light of a passage studied in its context.

Closing Reflection and Prayer

Reflection: When a belief I hold conflicts with Scripture rightly interpreted, am I prepared to allow God's Word to correct me?

Suggested prayer: Father, give us humble hearts to receive Your Word, wisdom to understand it rightly, courage to obey it, and love to share its truth with others. Help us glorify You in both what we teach and how we live. In Jesus' name, amen.

Teaching note: In 2 Timothy 3:15, the "sacred writings" Timothy knew from childhood refer especially to the Old Testament Scriptures. Christians read this passage alongside the New Testament witness to Christ and the apostles. The doctrine of the biblical canon deserves its own later lesson.